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The kinship system fills both these needs. In its normative aspects, it provides criteria by which actions can be judged as right or wrong. This is not to say that the kinship system furnishes an *en tout cas* cover of legislation for every eventuality; the values and ethics of the G/wi, as do those of every society, limit the field of legitimate grievance and, hence, the accepted causes of conflict. (To clarify this point by illustration: However much my conduct may offend the sensibilities of my rural neighbor, he has no legitimate grievance – and no accepted remedy – until I do something that is a recognized infringement of his rights.) In the G/wi case, the grievances regarded as legitimate are related to the rights and obligations governed by the kinship system or for which it provides a model.

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The behavior appropriate to the joking relationship permits free and trenchant public criticism of the actions of a joking partner and imposes an obligation to accept the criticism without the kind of resentment that might exacerbate the conflict. If a joking partner's action gives offense and this can be framed even in the most generalized context of kinship rights, obligations, and expectations, he can be taken to task. If he has a defense, it can be raised and the matter argued out in public.

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As the nominal hunter of the game animals that I shot, ≠ xwa: was responsible for dividing the meat. One evening, after he had given out portions of a gemsbok I had killed to compensate a group of men for the time they had given me, N/udukhwe suddenly began talking very loudly from his corner of the camp about the parsimony of "some hunters." He then addressed himself to a man seated near ≠ xwa: and me. "There are men so mean as to deny meat to a *gjiiba:xuma* [younger brother] who has helped all day with work."

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Other conversations died away and the whole band stopped to listen. "There is a man who stints when he should give." The man near us replied that it was shameful that such stinginess should occur between brothers (≠ xwa: and N/udukhwe were classificatory brothers). Launching his own tirade, ≠ xwa: directed his words to a man sitting near N/udukhwe: "People should not be hasty; it can happen that a man has much meat to divide and many portions to give out. Perhaps he pauses, seeing that other men want to rest awhile." Gjiudwe retorted, "Perhaps a man who is tired is also hungry and it is this that makes him hasty." Charge, defense, and countercharge ■ 173 were elaborated; ≠ xwa: was not very quick-witted and came off second-best in nearly every exchange. It was obvious that he had forgotten to give meat to N/udukhwe, but he was too vain to admit his mistake and not nimble enough to think up a face-saving excuse that carried any credence. In the end he called out to another man, Djedo'o (his closest friend), that he had nearly finished distributing meat and wanted help with carrying the last portion. (This was pretty lame. He had, in fact, given out the last piece some time previously and hadn't needed any help. However, the jeers that I expected did not come, perhaps because nobody wanted to detonate one of ≠ xwa:'s outbursts and fits of sulks.) Djedo'o came over and ≠ xwa: quietly asked him to give up some of his portion. This was added to what ≠ xwa: had kept for himself and the two men took the meat to N/udukhwe. In neglecting N/udukhwe in the first place, ≠ xwa: had simply been forgetful and I am certain that there was no malice in the oversight. His faux pas had cost him his share (and Djedo'o some of his), but nobody seemed at all sorry for him. He had made a silly mistake, compounded it by not admitting his error, and had paid for it.

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Human Relations Area Files

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